

DOES WHERE I'M BORN MAKE ME WHO I AM?

How did you get to be the person you are? Genetics might have given you traits such as your blood type and eye color, but what about the ways you act, think, and feel? There is a difference between what we are born knowing and doing and what we learn. For instance, all human beings have a biological need to eat, but what they eat, when they eat, and how they prepare food varies around the world. A person's whole way of life is described as culture.

CHANGING CULTURES

CULTURE VULTURES

The definition of culture depends on who you ask. A biologist will tell you that a culture is a colony of bacteria or other microorganisms. A suave and debonair person would describe culture as literature, art, music, and the performing arts. But anthropologists describe culture as the full range of learned human behavior: knowledge, beliefs, art, law, morals, language, customs, and traditions. Unlike instinctive behavior, culture is not something you are born with. Instead, you learn it from your family and surroundings.

"CULTURE IS THE WIDENING OF THE MIND AND OF THE SPIRIT."

Jawaharal Nehru (1889–1964),
Indian prime minister

SHARED CULTURE

Culture helps people feel togetherness and belonging. It gives people a way to communicate and interact with one another and helps establish order in society. Culture gives a group of people an identity that makes them unique. Culture is a very complex whole that can be broken down into smaller traits. These might be gestures, such as a handshake, or customs, such as wearing a veil, or celebrations, such as a wedding.

CULTURE SHOCK

Imagine if you were dropped into a completely different culture. At first, you might stick to your cultural traits of language or dialect. You might dress in the same clothes and eat the same foods as you did before. But the differences are likely to blur over time. You might see yourself as a member of a subculture within the new culture. You would probably adopt some new traits while keeping some of your old ways of life.

